

University of Alberta falls victim to witch-hunt mentality in professor's dismissal

If the university cannot see how dangerous it is to let one group dictate what the truth is and silence all other points of view, then it is in serious intellectual trouble



University of Alberta associate professor Kathleen Lowrey was dismissed as associate chair of

undergraduate studies in the department of anthropology in March. Lowrey says she believes she was dismissed over her critical views of gender.*SUPPLIED*

<https://nationalpost.com/opinion/columnists/gunter-u-of-a-falls-victim-to-witch-hunt-mentality-in-professors-dismissal/wcm/21c6d7ed-2306-4b12-987f-5c7071b473b2?fbclid=IwAR1DjxR3MUoPV-yhbEeU0mmYiOWzHq61PnsdErCeTsvIYoi3mBzkcR3NDmk>

LORNE GUNTER

June 11, 2020

7:00 AM EDT

I'm pretty sure U of A anthropology professor Kathleen Lowrey and I wouldn't see eye-to-eye on much. She's a Marxist and radical feminist. And I'm ... well, I'm neither of those.

But free speech doesn't mean much if you only defend it for people you agree with.

Free speech is useless unless it protects even speech you find offensive.

Lowrey has been fired from an administrative job (but not her teaching position) at the University of Alberta for being what her detractors would call a TERF – a Trans-Exclusionary Radical Feminist.

In short, there is a school of radical feminist thought which holds that women's rights should only apply to women who are biologically female. Trans women, therefore, are excluded.

I mostly disagree with the radical feminists. Women have faced stereotyping and inequality over the centuries not because they were given chromosome tests, but because they were perceived by society as women.

It's far more complicated these days with notions of "gender fluidity" and self-defined gender. However, cultural sexism is just as likely to apply to trans women as biological ones.

Still, the TERFs have some good points. Men who are transitioning to women have a profound advantage in women's sports and can make biological women feel unsafe at sexual assault centres or in prisons, so at the very least more-creative solutions are needed.

Wherever you stand, though, you shouldn't be silenced for your opinion.

But Lowrey was.

In addition to being an anthro prof, Lowrey was associate chair of her department's undergraduate programs from which she was dismissed without a hearing, without specific charges being made and without appeal.

All Lowrey was told by her department, the Faculty of Arts and something called the office of safe disclosure and human rights is that anonymous complainants claimed her "gender critical" opinions were making her classroom environment "unsafe" and causing "harm," presumably to transgender students.

This is the same kind of witch-hunt mentality that was once used by Christian moralists to purge gay and lesbian people from public positions and is now used by believers in many politically correct causes to silence opponents.

This mentality is also why defending Lowrey's freedom of expression is so crucial, even if you disagree vehemently with her position – because someday the same Star Chamber methods might be employed to shut you up if your views become unfashionable.

Local trans advocates say Lowrey's view that transgender identity doesn't trump biological sex in policy decisions denies their very existence and is therefore hateful and contrary to their Charter rights.

Trans advocates and their allies may indeed see TERF arguments as completely demeaning and hurtful, but the Charter merely defends all of our right to have our say, not some imagined right to never be confronted by views we find offensive or even obnoxious.

It's a modern twist of logic to believe we are never fully equal until everyone else agrees with us completely and affirms our beliefs.

In this particular case, the Charter should not protect trans women from ever having to hear viewpoints on gender that are contrary to their own. The Charter should never be interpreted as granting one group a right to decide what another group may say, even if that second group is completely offensive to the first.

If the University of Alberta cannot see how dangerous it is to let one group dictate what the truth is and silence all other points of view, then it is in serious intellectual trouble.

A university is supposed to be a crucible where all points of view were tested, not a blunt instrument used to bludgeon those who, like Lowrey, refuse to conform.

lgunter@postmedia.com